



EMS PROFESSIONAL LEARNING TEAMS · TEAM NORMS WORKSHEET

Holding Each Other Accountable

How to hold each other to your norms — and have the conversation when one gets broken

Norms only matter if the team keeps them, and eventually someone will slip — that's normal. What makes the difference is deciding in advance how you'll respond and having the words ready, so an awkward moment becomes a routine one. Work through this together before you need it.

1 · Agree on the protocol first (before anyone breaks a norm)

- ☐ **Give permission** — We all agree out loud that it's okay to be reminded — including me.
- ☐ **Pick an in-the-moment signal** — Choose one low-key cue anyone can use — point to the posted norms, or say “let's check our norms.”
- ☐ **Decide who addresses it** — The facilitator names it first in the meeting. If a pattern continues, it becomes a quiet peer-to-peer conversation.
- ☐ **Keep it two-way** — Everyone can give a reminder and everyone can receive one — no exceptions for seniority or role.

2 · The response ladder — start small

Match your response to the situation. Most slips never need more than the first rung.

Situation	How to respond
A one-time slip, in the moment	A light group cue — “Let's get back to our norm on ____.” No one is singled out.
It happens again	A quiet one-on-one after the meeting — never in front of the team.
A pattern that isn't changing	A structured conversation (below), ending in a specific next step you both agree to.

3 · The conversation — five moves

When it's time for a real conversation, keep it short and follow the order. Fill in the blanks for your situation.

1. Open gently, ask permission

“Can I check something with you? I want us to stay a strong team.”

2. Name the norm you agreed to

“We agreed we'd ____.”

3. Describe what you saw — behavior, not character

“In the last few meetings, I've noticed ____.”

4. Share the impact

“When that happens, ____ (the effect on the team or our students).”

5. Ask, and open the dialogue

“Can we _____? What would help? Is there something I’m missing?”

Then agree on one specific next step — and thank them for hearing you.

4 • Stems for the hard moments

To open it: *“I might be off base, but I want to raise something...” · “Because I care about this team, I...”*

If they get defensive: *“I’m not questioning your commitment — I’m naming a pattern I saw.” · “Help me understand what’s going on.”*

To stay on behavior: *“This isn’t about who you are; it’s about what we agreed to do.”*

To close: *“Thanks for hearing me. Can we agree to _____?”*

5 • Guardrails

- ☐ **Assume good intent** — Start curious, not accusing — most slips aren’t defiance.
- ☐ **Private, not public** — Praise in the room; correct one-on-one.
- ☐ **Behavior, not the person** — Name what was done, never who they are.
- ☐ **Timely, not saved up** — Address it close to when it happens, before resentment builds.
- ☐ **Two-way** — You’re open to the same reminder you’re giving.

6 • Practice it now (before it’s real)

Role-play it as a team: pick a norm, have someone gently “break” it, and practice the five moves. It’s far easier to do for real once you’ve rehearsed it once.

A norm we’ll practice the conversation with: _____

Our agreed in-the-moment signal: _____

Who names it first in meetings: _____

EMS Professional Learning Teams · 2026–27 · Original EMS worksheet. The conversation structure draws on widely used feedback and dialogue practices (e.g., Crucial Conversations, Patterson et al.).